Mandarin Grammar Refresher

Recovering conversational grammar

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Editorial draft ·Returning conversational speaker ·Traditional characters (automatically converted; not regionally adapted)

How to use this refresher

For you if: you once spoke Mandarin conversationally and still recognize much of the vocabulary, but now struggle to parse sentences or assemble your own. Explanations target a native English speaker's likely habits.

Goal: recover a usable grammar toolkit: find a sentence's backbone, attach its modifiers correctly, express time and results, and connect clauses without translating English word order.

This is modern conversational Mandarin with broadly mainland usage. It skips beginner vocabulary and pronunciation instruction. This traditional-character edition is generated from the simplified source; the regional variety is unchanged. Examples have English translations; pinyin appears only where a reading needs clarification.

Fast pass: read Sentence backbone, Time and aspect, and Complements; then do the parsing task. **Full pass:** work through the modules, say the examples aloud, and complete the two short application tasks. Revisit only the constructions that break down in use.

Notation: S = subject; V = verb; O = object. A *complement* follows a verb or adjective and adds a result, direction, degree, or similar information. Square brackets mark chunks for analysis. Patterns are practical defaults, not exhaustive rules.

Diagnostic: five minutes

Try these before reading. Check the Answer key afterward.

1. Parse **我昨天在地鐵上看的那篇文章很有意思。** What is the main claim? Which words belong inside the noun phrase? (Noun phrases)
2. Explain the difference between **我沒去** and **我不去了**. (Questions and negation; Time and aspect)
3. Explain the difference between **我看了那份報告**, **我看完了那份報告**, and **我看不懂那份報告**. (Time and aspect; Complements)
4. Say "Please send me the address" using 把. (Moving the object)
5. Compare **他們不都去** and **他們都不去**. (Questions and negation)

If unfamiliar vocabulary gets in the way, look it up or substitute familiar nouns. Keep the focus on structure.

Sentence backbone

Put the setting before the action

Default: S + time + place / other circumstances + V + O. Time can also precede S. Chinese verbs do not change form to mark English-style tense or agreement.

- **我明天在家工作。** I'll work at home tomorrow.
- **昨天她跟同事一起喫飯。** Yesterday she ate with her colleagues.

Pitfall: English often adds the setting afterward: "work at home." In the ordinary Chinese setting pattern, use **在家工作**. A location after the verb can instead describe the endpoint or resulting location: **放在桌上**, put it on the table. Position changes the relationship; it is not arbitrary.

For production, build the simple clause first: who, when, where/with whom, then the action.

Topics are what the sentence is about

Pattern: topic + comment. The topic may be an object, a setting, or a larger category; the comment can have its own subject. Context also allows omitted subjects and objects.

- **這家餐廳，我以前來過。** I've been to this restaurant before.
- **這件事，我還沒告訴她。** I haven't told her about this yet.

Pitfall: the first noun is not necessarily the person doing the action. In the second example, 這件事 is what is being discussed; 我 is the subject of 告訴. Recover omitted material from context rather than inventing a new English-style subject for every clause.

Identity, description, and existence use different tools

Patterns: A + 是 + noun phrase; S + degree word + adjective; place + 有 + thing; known thing + 在 + place.

- **她是工程師，最近很忙。** She's an engineer and has been busy lately.
- **樓下有一家咖啡店。那家店在銀行旁邊。** There's a café downstairs. That café is next to the bank.

Pitfall: do not insert 是 just because English uses "is." **她很忙** describes her; **她是工程師** identifies her. Unstressed 很 often makes a neutral adjective predicate sound natural; it need not mean an emphatic "very." Bare adjectives can occur in contrasts and other contexts: **這個貴，那個便宜。** This one is expensive; that one is cheap.

For negation: **不是** is not; **不忙** not busy; **沒有** there isn't / don't have; **不在** isn't at the location.

Noun phrases

Put descriptions before the noun with 的

Pattern: modifier + 的 + noun. The modifier can be an owner, a description, or a whole clause. Chinese puts a relative clause before the noun it identifies.

- **我昨天買的手機已經壞了。** The phone I bought yesterday has already broken.
- **坐在窗邊的那個人是我同事。** The person sitting by the window is my colleague.

Pitfall: English makes you expect "the person who …"; Chinese makes you wait for 人. In **[坐在窗邊的] 那個人**, the whole bracket describes the person. Find the noun after 的 before deciding what the main sentence says.

的 is often omitted in close relationships (**我媽媽**, my mother) and established compact descriptions (**中文書**, Chinese-language book). With a longer identifying clause, keeping 的 is the safe default. If the noun is understood, it can disappear: **紅的** means the red one(s).

Quantities need classifiers

Patterns: number + classifier + noun; 這/那 + classifier + noun. Classifiers categorize what is being counted; 個 is common but not universal.

- **我想買兩張票。** I'd like to buy two tickets.
- **這本書比那本便宜。** This book is cheaper than that one. (The second 書 is understood.)

Pitfall: use 兩 before most classifiers for "two": **兩個人**, two people. 二 is used in counting, ordinal numbers, and numbers such as 十二. **第二次** means the second time; **兩次** means twice. Useful familiar classifiers include 本 for books, 張 for tickets or flat items, 件 for matters or pieces of clothing, and 次 for occurrences.

Keep 的, 地, and 得 separate

They are usually pronounced neutral **de** in these grammatical uses, but they attach different things.

Form	Job	Example
Description + 的 + noun	Identify or describe a thing	**清楚的解釋**: a clear explanation
Manner + 地 + verb	Describe how an action is performed	**耐心地解釋**: explain patiently
Verb + 得 + description	Evaluate or describe an action	**解釋得很清楚**: explain very clearly

- **她認真地檢查了合同。** She carefully checked the contract.
- **她解釋得很清楚，我聽懂了。** She explained clearly, and I understood.

Pitfall: 得 is not a general substitute for 的. It follows the verb or adjective being expanded, not its object. See Complements for **中文說得很好** and for the separate potential use in **聽得懂**. 地 is often omitted in simple spoken manner phrases; its absence is not automatically an error.

Questions and negation

Ask without moving the question word

Patterns: statement + 嗎; V-not-V; question word in the position of the missing answer. Use 還是 for alternatives in a question and 或者 for alternatives in a statement.

- **你把鑰匙放在哪兒了?** Where did you put the keys? Compare the answer: **我把鑰匙放在桌上了。** I put them on the table.
- **你想今天去還是明天去?** Would you like to go today or tomorrow? **今天或者明天都可以。** Either today or tomorrow works.

Pitfall: keep the question word in the answer's slot: **你想喫什麼?** What do you want to eat? A subject question naturally starts with 誰: **誰想去?** Who wants to go? Neither needs 嗎. For a neutral yes/no question, choose **你去不去?** or **你去嗎?** , without combining the formats.

爲什麼 asks why; **怎麼** asks how, and can also express surprise or ask why: **你怎麼沒來?** How come you didn't come? **呢** can return the question to another topic: **我明天去。你呢?** I'm going tomorrow. What about you?

不 and 沒 deny different things

Default: 不 denies a habit, state, intention, or prediction; 沒 (有) denies occurrence or realization up to a reference time. 沒有 is also the negative of 有.

- **我平時不喝咖啡，但昨天喝了。** I don't usually drink coffee, but I did yesterday.
- **我今天還沒喝咖啡。** I haven't had coffee yet today.

Pitfall: these are not simply present versus past negatives. **他昨天不想出門。**He didn't want to go out yesterday. The desire is negated with 不 despite the past time. For an event that did not happen, say **沒買**, not 沒買了 with completed-event 了. Other sentence-final uses of 了 are a separate issue.

Use **別 + V** for "don't": **別着急。** Don't worry / don't rush. **別忘了帶鑰匙。** Don't forget to bring the keys. This fixed reminder also shows why "a negative can never appear with 了 " would be a bad rule.

Scope: what exactly does the negative cover?

Contrasts: 不都 = not all; 都不 = all not / none. 不一定 = not necessarily; 一定不 = definitely not.

- **他們不都住在北京。** Not all of them live in Beijing. **他們都不住在北京。** None of them live in Beijing.
- **他不一定來。** He may or may not come. **他一定不來。** He definitely won't come.

Pitfall: order determines scope: which claim is being added to, limited, or denied. **我也不去** means "I'm not going either"; **我不再去** means "I won't go anymore."

Question words can lose their question meaning in a construction such as **誰都知道。** Everyone knows. **我什麼都沒買。** I didn't buy anything. With negation and 都, do not translate 什麼 mechanically as a question.

Time and aspect

Time expressions say **when**. Aspect presents an event as realized, experienced, ongoing, or a maintained state. Chinese does not require every clause to carry an aspect particle. Context often supplies the time.

Verb 了: present an event as realized

Pattern: V + 了 + O, often with a quantity or other specification of the object. Perfective 了 views the event as a bounded occurrence; it does not by itself mean the entire task reached its intended endpoint.

- **我昨天看了三頁。** I read three pages yesterday.
- **明天喫了早飯再出門。** Tomorrow, go out after having breakfast.

Pitfall: 了 is not an English past-tense ending. The second example places the event in the future. And **我看了那本書，但是沒看完。** I read that book, but didn't finish it. To state completion of the whole reading task, use 完.

For a denial: **我沒看那本書。** I didn't read that book. For a question: **你看了沒有?** Did you read it? Past time alone does not require 了: **我小時候住在上海。** I lived in Shanghai as a child.

Sentence-final 了: update the situation

Pattern: clause + 了. It signals a changed situation or a newly relevant state. At the end of a short sentence, the event and situation-update readings can overlap; not every 了 can be classified by position alone.

- **現在不下雨了。** It's not raining anymore.
- **我不去了。** I'm not going after all / anymore.

Pitfall: compare **我沒去** (I didn't go) with **我不去了** (I've changed my plan / won't go now). The latter is an update about the situation, not a completed negative action.

我餓了。 I'm hungry now. No completed action needs to be imagined. **快下雨了。** It's going to rain soon. Again, nothing has happened yet.

For possession or availability, negate 有 with 沒有: **我沒有現金了。** I'm out of cash. "No longer" is not always 不…了.

過: experience, rather than an event report

Pattern: V + 過 + O; negative 沒 (有) + V + 過 + O. 過 presents an experience before the relevant reference time, often at least once.

- **我去過成都，但沒去過重慶。** I've been to Chengdu, but not Chongqing.
- **這道菜我以前喫過。** I've had this dish before.

Pitfall: 昨天我去了成都 reports a particular trip yesterday; **我去過成都** foregrounds having that experience. English "have" does not automatically call for 過: "I've lost my keys" would ordinarily be **我的鑰匙丟了**, an event/current problem, rather than a claim about prior experience.

在 and 着: ongoing actions and states

Patterns: 在/正在 + V foregrounds an action in progress; V + 着 often presents a continuing state or background action. 着 is **zhe** here, not the **zháo** in 睡着 (fall asleep).

- **她正在開門。門開着呢。** She's opening the door. The door is open.
- **他戴着耳機工作。** He's working with headphones on.

Pitfall: 開着 describes the open state in this context, not the motion of opening. Do not add 在 to every English "-ing": adjective states and activities that Chinese presents differently need their own constructions. **我知道** means "I know"; it is not normally 正在知道.

我在看書呢。 I'm reading. 呢 can reinforce an ongoing scene; it does not mark progression in every use. 着 can also accompany an ongoing activity, so the distinction is about focus, not simply "action versus no action."

Duration, frequency, and "still continuing"

Defaults: put time-when before the action and duration after the verb. With an object, repeating the verb is one clear way to attach duration. 次 counts occurrences; 遍 counts complete passes through material.

- **我昨天看書看了兩個小時。** I read for two hours yesterday.
- **我已經學了三年中文了。** I've been studying Chinese for three years now.

Pitfall: distinguish **三年前** (three years ago), **三年** (for three years), and **三次** (three times). The second example normally suggests study continuing to now. Final 了 relates the accumulated duration to the present; context determines whether study continues. Compare **我以前學過三年中文。** I previously studied Chinese for three years.

看了兩次 means read/looked at it twice; **看了兩遍** specifies two passes from beginning to end. Neither guarantees understanding. **十分鐘以後再來** means come back in ten minutes, not stay for ten minutes.

Complements

Read the verb and its complement together before translating. 聽懂, 聽得懂, and 聽不懂 make different claims.

Result: what did the action achieve?

Pattern: V + result, optionally followed by 了 and an object. Common results: 完 finished, 懂 understood, 到 reached/obtained, 見 perceived, 好 ready/satisfactorily done, 錯 wrong.

- **我聽見了，但沒聽懂。** I heard it, but didn't understand.
- **我把地址寫錯了。** I wrote the address incorrectly.

Pitfall: **聽** means listen; **聽見** means hear; **聽懂** means understand what one hears. An action and a successful result are different claims. **找了很久，還是沒找到。** I looked for a long time and still didn't find it.

完 gives an endpoint, whereas 好 often suggests readiness or satisfactory completion: **飯做好了。** The meal is ready. A result complement does not itself locate the event in the past: **看完再告訴我。** Tell me after you finish reading.

Potential: can the result be achieved?

Pattern: V + 得 / 不 + result or directional complement. This often describes practical possibility under the circumstances. The negative is inside the package.

- **你說慢一點兒，我就聽得懂。** If you speak a little more slowly, I can understand.
- **這個箱子太大，放不進去。** This box is too big; it won't fit inside.

Pitfall: **沒聽懂** reports that understanding did not happen; **聽不懂** says you cannot make sense of it under the current conditions. **聽不見** means you cannot hear it. **不能聽** concerns the possibility or permission to listen, without specifically identifying failure to understand.

Compare **這份報告我今天寫不完。**I can't finish this report today. **這份報告我今天不寫，明天再寫。**I'm not writing this report today; I'll write it tomorrow. Inability to achieve a result differs from deciding not to act.

Degree and manner: how well, how far, with what effect?

Pattern: V + 得 + description; adjective + 得 + consequence. If the verb has an object, move the object earlier or repeat the verb.

- **她中文說得很流利。** She speaks Chinese fluently. Also: **她說中文說得很流利。**
- **我累得不想說話。** I'm so tired I don't want to talk.

Pitfall: don't leave the object between the verb and 得: for "speaks Chinese well," use **中文說得很好** or **說中文說得很好**. To deny the quality, say **說得不好**, not 不說得好. **不說** would deny speaking.

The 得 in **聽得懂** marks potential, while **說得很清楚** evaluates clarity. Some short forms, such as **做得好**, can depend on context. Longer descriptive phrases and the corresponding negative often reveal the construction: **做得不好** evaluates quality; **做不好** can express inability to achieve a good result.

Direction: movement relative to a viewpoint

Pattern: V + direction + 來/去. 來 moves toward the contextual viewpoint; 去 moves away. Frequent combinations include 進來/進去, 出來/出去, 回來/回去, 上來/上去, 下來/下去.

- **外面太冷了，快進來。** It's too cold outside; come in.
- **請把這把椅子搬出去。** Please move this chair out.

Pitfall: choose 來/去 by viewpoint, not by the English word "in." With a place object, put the place before the final 來/去: **走進教室來**, walk into the classroom toward the viewpoint. With an object being moved, 把 often keeps the structure clear, as in the chair example.

Direction also extends beyond physical movement: **想起來了** means remembered; **繼續說下去** means keep speaking. Learn these as meaning-bearing chunks rather than translating each character literally.

Moving the object

把: foreground what happens to a particular thing

Pattern: S + (negation / modal) + 把 + identifiable O + V + result / destination / other elaboration. Use it to track an affected object and what is done to it.

- **請把地址發給我。** Please send me the address.
- **我沒把那份報告看完。** I didn't finish reading that report.

Pitfall: 把 is not a generic object marker for every transitive sentence. A safe production strategy is a known/specified object and a concrete outcome. **把門關上** (close the door) and **把書放在桌上** (put the book on the table) are useful packages. Verbs such as 喜歡 do not ordinarily describe this kind of handling: **我喜歡這本書。** I like this book.

Place the clause-level negation or modal before 把: **別把手機忘在車裏。** Don't leave your phone in the car. A bare verb after the object often feels incomplete; add a result, destination, or other elaboration. **把這段話讀一下。** Take a moment to read this passage. 一下 elaborates the action without naming a result.

被: foreground the affected participant

Pattern: affected S + 被 + (agent) + V + result / elaboration. The agent may be omitted. Common in adverse events, but not limited to them.

- **我的自行車被人偷走了。** My bicycle was stolen.
- **這個問題已經被解決了。** This problem has already been solved.

Pitfall: do not turn every English passive into 被. Chinese can often leave an agent unexpressed without a passive marker: **票買好了。** The tickets have been bought / are all sorted. Use 被 when the affected participant and what happened to it deserve attention.

For a negative: **門沒被鎖上。** The door wasn't locked. Recognize conversational passives with 讓 or 叫 too, but remember that those words also mean let/make and call. Context must decide.

Comparisons and modals

Compare along a stated dimension

Patterns: A + 比 + B + adjective; A + 沒有 + B + adjective; A + 跟 + B + 一樣 + adjective. Put an exact difference after the adjective.

- **這條路比那條短兩公里。** This route is two kilometers shorter than that one.
- **今天沒有昨天那麼冷。** Today isn't as cold as yesterday. **這間房跟那間一樣大。** This room is as big as that one.

Pitfall: use **比以前好得多** (much better than before), not 比以前很好 for the ordinary comparative. **不比** denies being more; **沒有** states falling short: **他不比我高** says he isn't taller than me, allowing equal height; **他沒有我高** says he isn't as tall as me.

越來越 + adjective expresses change over time: **天氣越來越熱。** The weather is getting hotter. **越 A 越 B** links variation in A to variation in B: **越說越流利。** The more you speak, the more fluent you become.

會, 能, 可以, 想, 要: choose the relationship

Default meanings: 會 learned ability or prediction; 能 ability/possibility under circumstances; 可以 permission or acceptable possibility; 想 desire/intention; 要 want, intend, require, or an imminent development, depending on context.

- **我會開車，但今天太累，不能開。** I can drive, but I'm too tired to drive today.
- **這裏可以停車嗎？我想停十分鐘。** Is parking allowed here? I'd like to park for ten minutes.

Pitfall: these overlap, but they are not interchangeable translations of "can" and "will." **他會來的。** He'll come (a confident prediction). **他要來了。** He's about to come. **我不會游泳。** I don't know how to swim. **我不能游泳。** I can't swim in the present circumstances / am not allowed to.

For "don't need to," use **不用** or **不必**: **你不用等我。** You don't need to wait for me. **不要等我** is an instruction not to wait, not a statement that waiting is unnecessary. **應該** means should: **你應該早點休息。** You should get some rest earlier.

Connectors and conversational framing

就 and 才: timing, thresholds, and expectations

Patterns: time / condition + 就 + action; time / condition + 才 + action. 就 often suggests promptness, sufficiency, or "then"; 才 often marks a late threshold or "only then." Their other uses depend on construction.

- **他七點就到了，我九點纔到。** He arrived as early as seven; I didn't arrive until nine.
- **十分鐘就夠了。** Ten minutes is enough. **我纔等了十分鐘。** I've only waited ten minutes.

Pitfall: 才 can mark a late threshold or a surprisingly small quantity. Compare "not until nine" with "only ten minutes." Read the time or quantity it comments on; neither 才 nor 就 has one fixed English translation.

一到家就給我打電話。 Call me as soon as you get home. Here 一...就...links an immediate sequence; it is not a count of one phone call.

又, 再, 還, 已經: orient the event

Defaults: 又 repeats an occurrence; 再 proposes or projects repetition / a later next step; 還 means still or additionally; 已經 means already.

- **他昨天又遲到了。明天別再遲到了。** He was late again yesterday. Don't be late again tomorrow.
- **我已經喫過了，但她還沒喫。** I've already eaten, but she hasn't eaten yet.

Pitfall: 又 and 再 are not fixed past and future tense markers. **明天又是星期一。** Tomorrow it's Monday again. It presents a recurring situation even though it is future. Use construction and perspective, rather than an English tense rule.

先喫飯，再討論。 Eat first, then discuss it. 再 here orders a next step. **還要一杯水。** I'd also like a glass of water. 還 adds an item; that need not mean a second glass of water. It is hái here; huán means return/give back in a different lexical use.

Connect the logic of clauses

Useful pairs: 因爲…所以…because/therefore; 雖然…但是…although/but; 如果/要是…就…if/then; 只要…就… provided/then; 只有…才…only if/only then.

- **雖然很忙，但是我還是想去。** Although I'm busy, I still want to go.
- **只要有時間，我就去。只有週末，我纔有時間。** As long as I have time, I'll go. I only have time on weekends.

Pitfall: Chinese commonly uses both halves of 因爲…所以...and 雖然…但是..., unlike their usual English translations. One half can be omitted when the relation is clear. **只要** makes its condition sufficient: having time is enough for me to go. **只有** makes its condition necessary: being a weekend is required for me to have time.

For ordinary sentences, connect nouns with 和/跟, and clauses with an appropriate connector or a pause: **我買了菜，然後回家做飯。** I bought groceries, then went home to cook. Do not use 和 as the default English "and" between full clauses. **一邊做飯一邊聽播客。** Cook while listening to a podcast: two simultaneous activities.

是...的: focus on a detail

Pattern: S + 是 + focused time / place / manner / agent detail + V + 的. A major use highlights details of an event treated as established in the conversation. 是 is often omitted in affirmative speech.

- **我是去年搬來的。** It was last year that I moved here.
- **這張照片是我朋友拍的。** This photo was taken by my friend. (Focus on who took it.)

Pitfall: 我去年搬來了 reports the move; **我是去年搬來的** highlights when. To deny the focused detail, retain 是: **我不是去年搬來的，是前年。** I moved here the year before last, not last year. A different emphatic 是…的 pattern can concern the future: **他是會來的。** He really will come. Do not treat 是…的 as a past-tense ending.

Small forms that make speech usable

Patterns: V + 一下 or verb reduplication for a brief/limited action; 吧 for suggestions or softened directives; 呢 for a continuing topic or scene. These affect conversational stance as well as literal content.

- **你看一下這個地址，對不對?** Take a quick look at this address. Is it right?
- **我們先坐下聊聊吧。** Let's sit down and chat for a bit first.

Pitfall: particles do not automatically make every demand polite. Relationship, intonation, and wording still matter. **給我看看。** Let me have a look. This can be ordinary among friends, but a more considerate request to a stranger is **可以讓我看一下嗎?** Could you let me take a quick look?

Contextual pronunciation worth recognizing

These readings help connect a familiar character to its grammatical role:

- **不** is normally bù; before a fourth tone it becomes bú: **不是** bú shì. **一** changes in many connected contexts: **一天** yì tiān; **一個** yí ge (個 is commonly neutral, with an underlying fourth tone). Counting and ordinals often retain yī. In **去不去** qù bu qù and **看一看** kàn yi kàn, the middle syllable is commonly neutral. Dictionaries may show underlying tones.

- **了** is neutral le as a particle, but liǎo in **受不了** shòu bu liǎo (can't stand it). **得** is neutral de in complements, děi in **我得走了** (I have to go), and dé in **得到** (obtain).

Pitfall: identical characters can have different readings within one sentence. In Task 2, **去不了了** is qù bu liǎo le: "cannot go" plus a situation update.

Apply it

Task 1: parse before translating

Spend five to ten minutes on this paragraph. Bracket the long noun phrase, identify the main predicates, and label the result, potential, and 把 constructions. Then give an idiomatic English translation.

我昨天在地鐵上看的那篇文章，你看完了嗎？我看了兩遍，還是有幾句看不懂。你要是有時間，就把最難的那一段給我解釋一下吧。

Check that you can explain what the speaker read, what remains difficult, and what help they request.

Task 2: recover a useful message

Write or say a six-to-eight-sentence message to a friend. You planned to meet tonight, worked longer than expected, have not finished a report, and propose meeting tomorrow instead. Include:

- A contrast between the original plan and the updated situation.
- An unachieved result, not just a negated action.
- A conditional proposal.
- A request to send you the address, and a statement about what to do on arrival.

Spend ten minutes, then compare with the model. Different wording is welcome. A listener should be able to reconstruct your plan, the obstacle, and the requested next steps.

Answer key

Diagnostic

1. **[我昨天在地鐵上看的] 那篇文章 / 很有意思。** Main claim: that article is interesting. The bracket means "that I read on the subway yesterday"; it modifies 文章. 我 is the subject inside the modifier, not the subject of 很有意思. Translate: "The article I read on the subway yesterday is interesting."
2. **我沒去**: I didn't go / haven't gone. It denies the occurrence. **我不去了**: I'm not going after all / anymore. It updates the plan or situation.
3. **我看了那份報告**: I read that report; it does not by itself guarantee I finished it. **我看完了那份報告**: I finished reading it. **我看不懂那份報告**: I can't understand the report. The final two use result and potential complements, respectively.
4. **請把地址發給我。** 請 softens the request; 把 introduces the identifiable address; 發給我 states the transfer to me.
5. **他們不都去**: not all of them are going. **他們都不去**: none of them are going. In this context, 不 before 都 denies the universal claim; 都 before 不 distributes the negative across everyone.

Task 1 model

[我昨天在地鐵上看的] 那篇文章，你看完了嗎？ The bracket modifies 文章, and the entire article phrase is the topic. Main clause: 你看完了嗎? **看完** is read + finish.

我看了兩遍，還是有幾句看不懂。 The speaker read it twice; 遍 counts complete passes through material. **看不懂** is inability to understand; **有幾句** introduces the few sentences that remain problematic. Reading through something and understanding it are separate outcomes.

你要是有時間，就把最難的那一段給我解釋一下吧。要是...就...gives a condition and requested response. 把 marks the particular paragraph to be explained. **給我** identifies the person receiving the explanation. 一下 limits the request, and 吧 softens it.

"Have you finished reading the article I read on the subway yesterday? I've read it twice, but there are still a few sentences I can't understand. If you have time, could you explain the hardest paragraph to me?"

Task 2 model

我們本來約好今晚見面。可是我今天加班，九點才下班。報告還沒寫完。我今晚去不了了。要是你明天有時間，我們就明天見吧。請把地址發給我。我到了以後就給你打電話。

"We originally agreed to meet tonight. But I worked overtime today and didn't get off work until nine. The report still isn't finished. I can't make it tonight after all. If you have time tomorrow, let's meet tomorrow. Please send me the address. I'll call you once I arrive."

Notice **才** marking a late time, **沒寫完** denying an achieved result, **去不了** describing inability to go, and final **了** updating the situation. **到了以後** establishes arrival as the condition for the later call; it does not make the call a past event.

Quick reference

A parsing routine

1. Find the main predicate. Does it say identity (是), description (adjective), existence (有), location (在), or an action?
2. Bracket each long **...的 + noun** group. Find where the modifier ends before interpreting the main clause.
3. Recover the topic, subject, and omitted objects from context.
4. Read the full verb package: action + result/direction; potential 得/不; descriptive 得; aspect particles.
5. Check negation and adverb scope. Then connect clauses by time, condition, contrast, or cause.

Choose the construction by the message

What you want to say	Useful pattern
Present an event as realized	V + 了; not required for every past event
A situation has changed	Clause + 了
Something did not happen	沒 (有) + V
No longer / no longer have	不 + predicate + 了 / 沒有 + noun + 了
You have prior experience	V + 過
An action is in progress	在/正在 + V
State / background activity	V + 着
An action achieved a result	V + result

What you want to say	Useful pattern
A result cannot be achieved	V + 不 + result
You describe performance	V + 得 + description
A known object is handled	把 + O + V + elaboration
A participant is affected	Affected S + 被 + (agent) + V…
You identify a thing	Modifier + 的 + noun
You highlight an event detail	是 + detail + V + 的

Recover by producing contrasts

After reading, make one personal sentence for each pair: 不/沒; 了/過; 在/着; 沒聽懂/聽不懂; 不都/都不; 就/才; 只要/只有. If the meaning changes as intended, move on. If not, return to that unit and say the examples in a new context.

Sources and further review

This original teaching draft received an editorial pass for accuracy, example naturalness, translation, and density on 2026-11-10. It has not received independent human language review. These teaching references support further study and the distinctions checked during revision.

- University of Oxford, Centre for Teaching Chinese as a Foreign Language, grammar database index. Further explanations of aspect, complements, word order, and related constructions.
- Oxford CTCFL, the 得 construction and potential complements: object placement, descriptive versus potential 得, and negation; the 把 construction: affected objects and elaborated verb phrases; comparatives: 比, 沒有, and 一樣.
- Palacký University Olomouc, ChinGram, teacher's guide to 着/著: persistent states, accompanying actions, and the contrast with 在.
- Education University of Hong Kong, tone sandhi of 一: contextual tone changes, with recorded examples.
- Cheng & Tsui, *Integrated Chinese*, third edition, Level 1 Part 1, publisher's lesson sample, grammar discussion of 了: why it is not a past-tense marker, including future event sequences.
- OpenCC project: the tool used for the optional traditional-character edition. Automated script conversion does not establish regional usage or linguistic review.

The initial references were checked on 2026-11-09; the editorial pass added targeted checks on 2026-11-10. Human language review remains the next step before marking the course independently reviewed.